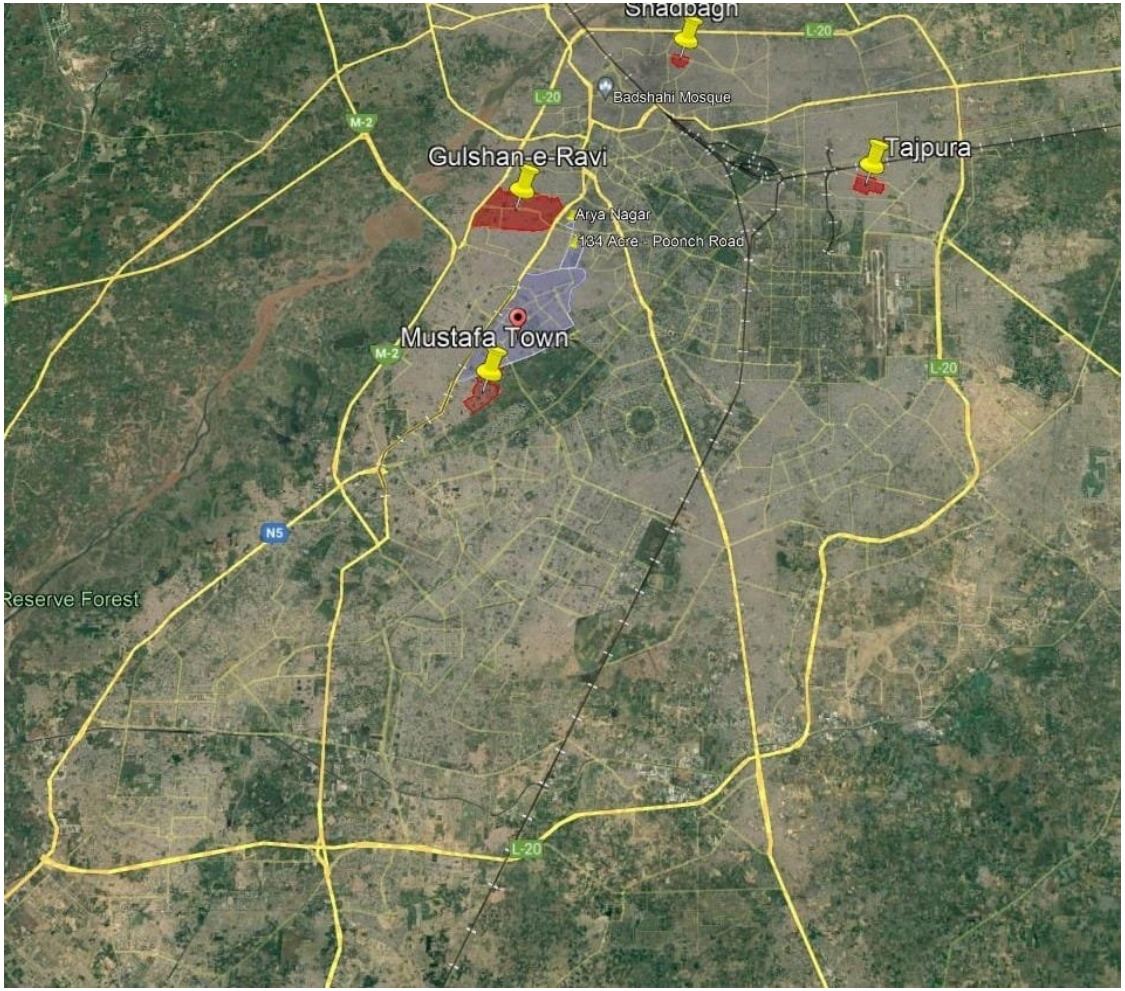
PORTFOLIO 2026

Amna Bashir

Architect

I design public buildings for the Government of Punjab, and research how Lahore's parks, markets and mosques can work for everyone who uses them — women included.

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01

Implications of COVID-19 Pandemic on Behavioural Patterns of Users of Public Spaces in Lahore

How the COVID-19 pandemic changed the way people in four Lahore neighbourhoods use their parks, markets and mosques — and what it revealed about who those spaces were built for.

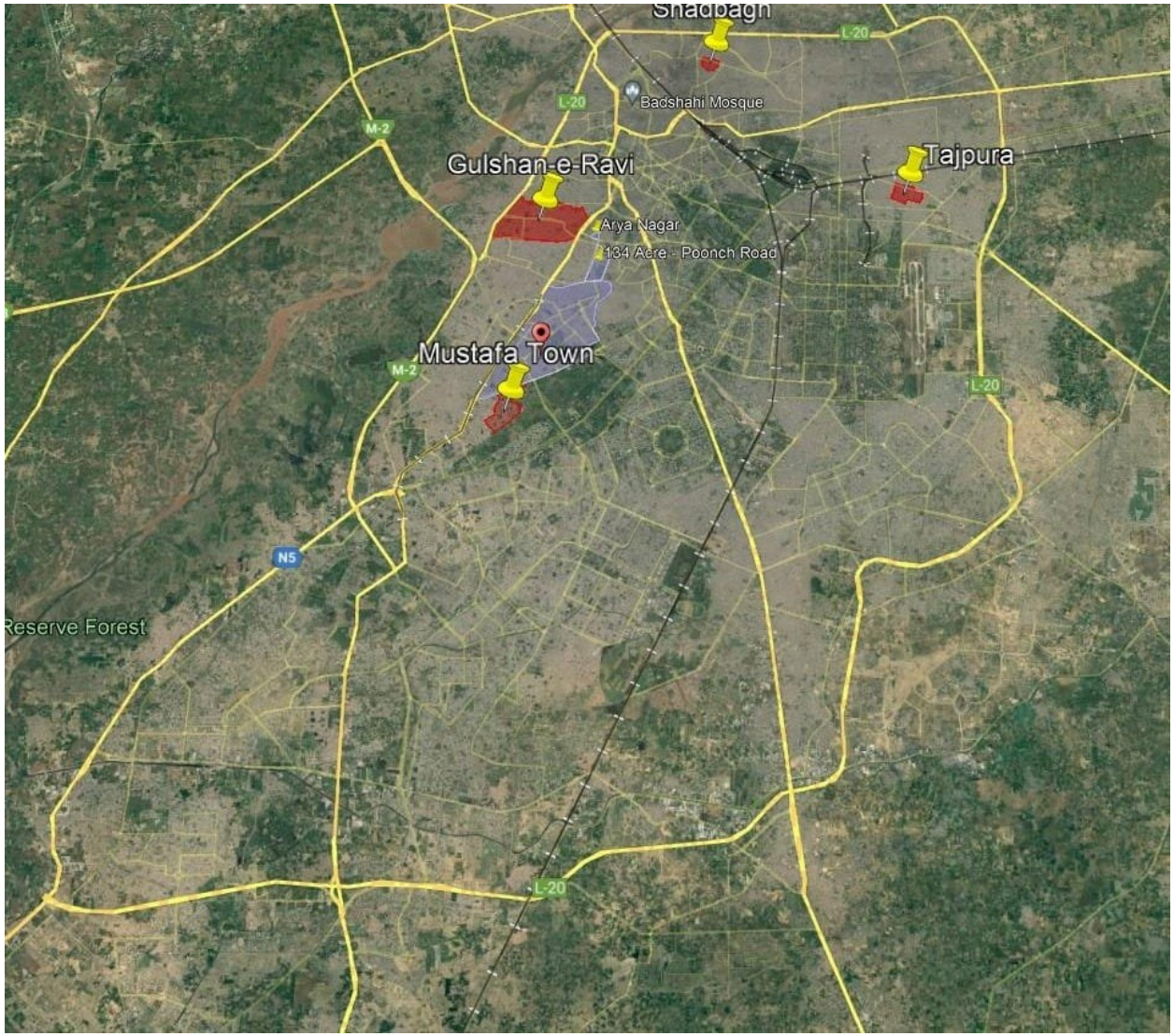
ROLE Sole researcher and author	STUDIO Department of Architecture, University of Engineering and Technology, Lahore
LOCATION Lahore, Pakistan	YEAR 2025
STATUS Academic	TYPOLOGY Urban research, Public space

CREDITS

Supervised by Dr. Maryam Siddiq, Department of Architecture, UET Lahore.

BRIEF

When the pandemic closed Lahore's public spaces, it showed how much daily life depends on them, and how little was known about how residents actually use them. This thesis set out to record what changed in the parks, markets and mosques of four Lahore Development Authority housing schemes, before and during COVID-19: how often people came, what they did there, how safe they felt, and whether the spaces served women and men equally.



IMPLICATIONS OF COVID-19 PANDEMIC ON BEHAVIOURAL PATTERNS OF USERS OF PUBLIC SPACES IN LAHORE – RESEARCH QUESTIONS

1. How did the use of Lahore's public spaces change before and during the COVID-19 pandemic, and what drove those changes?
2. How did the pandemic change the way people behave in public space?
3. How did users perceive the safety, attractiveness and usability of public spaces before and during the pandemic?
4. To what extent are Lahore's public spaces androcentric — designed around men — and did the pandemic deepen that bias?
5. What changes to policy and management would make public spaces more resilient to future health crises?

METHODS

Survey. A structured questionnaire in English and Urdu, with closed and Likert-scale questions on how often and why residents used parks, markets and mosques and how safe they felt, asked for the period before the pandemic and during it. Collected in person, with COVID-19 precautions, from 24 June to 6 July 2022.

Interviews. Semi-structured interviews with women, men and young people aged 15 to 55, held in Urdu between 6 and 21 July 2022, transcribed into English and analysed thematically.

Observation. Non-participant observation at a park, a market and a mosque in each scheme over several weeks, at different times of day and week — recording group sizes, distancing, mask use and the activities taking place.

Spatial analysis. Land-use maps, satellite base maps, a visual audit and a photographic survey of each site, read against Google Community Mobility Reports for Lahore from March, May and July 2020.

Fieldwork. Mustafa Town, Shadbagh, Gulshan-e-Ravi, Tajpura

FINDINGS

Parks mattered more. Walking and exercise rose in all four parks during the pandemic while lingering and gathering fell: parks became places for physical and mental health rather than for socialising, and residents with little private outdoor space relied on them most.

Markets shrank to transactions. Every kind of market activity fell. Shopping became planned, quick and increasingly contactless, women withdrew from markets without visible safety measures, and informal vendors bore the economic loss.

A gendered wall around the mosque. Men's attendance fell and worship adapted — ablution at home, distanced rows, verbal greetings in place of handshakes. Women were already excluded: none of the surveyed mosques had a prayer area for women, so the pandemic revealed that exclusion rather than causing it.

Safety felt unequally. Men largely felt safe in the parks; women avoided poorly lit parks in the evening. The pandemic acted as both a mirror and a magnifier of the gender inequities already built into these spaces.

What makes a space feel safe changed. Before the pandemic users judged public space by lighting, surveillance and amenities; during it, by openness, distance from others and the risk of exposure.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Women-led safety audits. Audit neighbourhood parks and markets with women, to find the dark corners, single gates and missing facilities that keep them away.

Light, sightlines and exits. Reliable solar LED lighting, trimmed planting, transparent boundaries and more than one entrance, so that no one feels trapped.

Activity zoning. Family zones near entrances, walking tracks along open edges and quiet green corners, so women can choose where they feel comfortable.

Women in mosques. Prayer areas, separate well-lit entrances and ablution spaces for women in new and existing mosques, and women on mosque committees.

Measure who comes. Track women's use of each space for six to twelve months after every intervention, so design decisions are judged by who actually uses the result.

OUTCOME

The thesis closes with site-specific recommendations for the Lahore Development Authority — from women-led safety audits and better-lit, more open park layouts to prayer areas and separate entrances for women in neighbourhood mosques — and a set of design principles for public space after the pandemic.

ABOUT

I am an architect in Lahore. Since 2022 I have worked as Assistant Director Architecture in the Punjab Architecture Department of the Communication & Works Department, designing and managing public building projects for the Government of Punjab. I graduated from Lahore College for Women University as the gold medallist of the Bachelor of Architecture.

EDUCATION

Master of Architecture (M.Arch), University of Engineering and Technology, Lahore

Bachelor of Architecture (B.Arch), Lahore College for Women University, 2017 — Gold medallist

REGISTRATION

Member, Pakistan Council of Architects and Town Planners (PCATP) (A-07057)

Member, Institute of Architects, Pakistan (IAP) (A-2353-22)

EXPERIENCE

Assistant Director Architecture (CAD), Punjab Architecture Department, Communication & Works Department, Government of Punjab — Mar 2022 – Present

Visiting Lecturer, Department of Architecture, Lahore College for Women University — Aug 2019 – Feb 2022

Architect, Kazmain Design & Interior Contractors — Mar 2019 – Feb 2022

Architecture Intern, Allied Engineering Consultants — Aug 2016 – Sep 2016

Architecture Intern, UNICON Consulting Service — Aug 2015 – Sep 2015

SOFTWARE

AutoCAD · Revit · SketchUp · Adobe Photoshop · Adobe Illustrator · Prezi · Microsoft Office

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